

ROAD TO SAINTHOOD

STEP 1 DIOCESAN INVESTIGATION

1. A diocese, parish or congregation petitions the bishop of the diocese in which the candidate died to open the process for canonisation.
2. After an approval from the Vatican, the bishop forms a tribunal.
3. The tribunal summons witnesses to recount the candidate's "heroic exercise of Christian deeds"

and collects documents.
4. The candidate is bestowed as Servant of God.

STEP 2 VATICAN INVESTIGATION

1. All documents are passed on to Congregation of Cause of Saints at the Vatican.
2. Nine theologians examine the cause.
3. If passed, the cause is examined by the Congregation of Cause of Saints.

4. If passed, the cause is presented to the Pope for approval. A decree is passed and read publicly.

STEP 3 BEATIFICATION

1. Miracle attributed to the candidate (not required for martyrs) to be presented.
2. Appropriate investigation into the miracle by the Vatican.
3. If approved, the Pope declares the candidate

beatified and grants the title, Blessed.

STEP 4 CANONISATION

1. A posthumous miracle occurred through the intercession of the Blessed and happened after the beatification to be presented.
2. Appropriate investigation into the miracle including confirmation by medical doctors, etc.
3. The Pope decides on the canonisation.



ONE OF THEIR OWN:
Thousands queued up last Sunday to pay homage to India's first woman saint at Bharananganam

to a detailed investigation, including confirmation by a five-member medical panel. In 2008, Vatican approved the miracle, clearing the decks for canonisation. Jinil and his parents were at the Vatican to witness the canonisation ceremony.

Despite the miracles and legends around Alphonsa, nothing is more conspicuous than her poor background and life of suffering. Interestingly India's first woman saint who studied only up to Class VII and hailed from a poor family was confined to the convent most of her life with no public life of service or charity unlike celebrated souls like Mother Teresa or Fr. Damien who are yet to be canonised. Bernard

Moras, Archbishop of Bangalore, puts it succinctly, "Alphonsa had no remarkable feats to applaud. Yet her greatness as a handmaiden of the Lord endears her to all of us." The 90-year-old Mary Veliparambil, a former cook at the FCC convent when Alphonsa was an inmate, remembers how she prepared a special herbal chutney for the perpetually sick nun.

Despite the festivities across the state, there is a small band of critics as well. Joseph Pulikkunnel, a noted Christian theologian living in Bharananganam, is one. "I was also a witness at her spartan funeral. She was an embodiment of humility and love. But that the church is the richest corporate body and celebrates most ostentatiously makes poor Alphonsa's sainthood an irony," says Pulikkunnel, who heads Osana, a Christian study centre.

For all the carping critics, there are thousands who regard Alphonsa's sainthood as richly deserved. The fact that Kerala calls itself God's Own Country lends it another dimension. Certainly, sainthood is so rare that it is likely to witness an entire tourist industry being spawned around the saint. Travel agents have already converged on Bharananganam. That may be an inevitable sideshow but the main issue is that it will provide a huge boost to the church, particularly the SMC. With the community being targeted in Orissa, a miracle is needed to shake the state Government out of its shameful slumber. The last word comes from Kalariparambil: "God intervenes," she says, "when Satan makes his cruellest manifestation."



SHANKAR